

ROCKERS

"I know I know... I've worked on the damned thing all week and it's still not right. Maybe if you stop breathing down my neck, or better yet, just leave me the fuck alone and I'll get it done."

Nockers are as well known for their cynicism and bitterness as they are for being master crafters. They are also fiercely individualistic and belittle anything that does not match their own ideal of artistic perfection. They prefer to create and surround themselves with treasures of mechanical wonder, rather than interact with "imperfect" people. When they are forced to have social contact they are eminently sarcastic with everyone around them, and blazingly critical of anyone in charge.

The bone-trembling nervousness of beginning a new project, the unbridled joy of completing the work of art, and the heart-wrenching angst of suffering through criticism — of all these things are intrinsic to the nockers. Artists, builders, crafters, and even writers all know the torment of "knowing" that their work is not good enough, that it will never be understood. And yet, they toil on, day after day, seeking perfection that they will never find. Early legends speak of goblins and kobolds who endlessly toiled deep beneath the earth, mining, smelting and crafting, and of other diminutive beings who made toys to leave for children who were good and kind. It is from these legends that nockers were born.

Nockers are innovators to the extreme, always seeking out the newest and edgiest feats of engineering and craftsmanship. A younger nocker may explore many different styles and techniques before settling down and finding her niche, at which point she becomes known as an eccentric genius in her field. Sometimes other Kithain seek out such a master, hoping to learn from her artistry, but they must be strong of will to withstand the maestro's insults and withering criticism. Nockers have developed a complex ritual of insults and disparagements that constitute greetings and familiarity. Between nockers this is as natural as two businessmen shaking hands.

For nockers, people are a mystery. People are mercurial, have feelings that can be easily hurt, and once broken they cannot be repaired in the same way as a tool or device. Truth be told, the soul of a nocker is as poetic as any of the Kithain. Perhaps their deepest secret is that they are, at heart, romantics. They deeply long to escape their flawed and obsessive lives and are drawn to music, art, and even courtly love, though of course they will never admit it. Unfortunately, nockers cannot help but

treat romantic relationships like everything else and will poke and tinker until they are broken.

Appearance: Though not as hideous as the goblins of legend, nockers are nonetheless grotesque in their own right. They tend to have thick, reddish skin and elongated arms and legs. Their long, spindly fingers have thick, knotty knuckles and sharp black talons. They have hatchet faces that appear mask-like and are pasty white with red noses and cheeks. They often paint swirls or patterns around or under the eyes or on their cheeks. They usually have stark white hair with large busy eyebrows above their rat-like eyes. A nockler's rare smile reveals a row of sharp pointed teeth. In the workshop they

prefer heavy overalls, often adorned with large brass buckles and buttons. At court, they are second only to the sidhe in fashion and complexity, favoring spiral and swirling patterns. Even when at court a nocker wouldn't be caught dead without a few favorite tools on his person.

